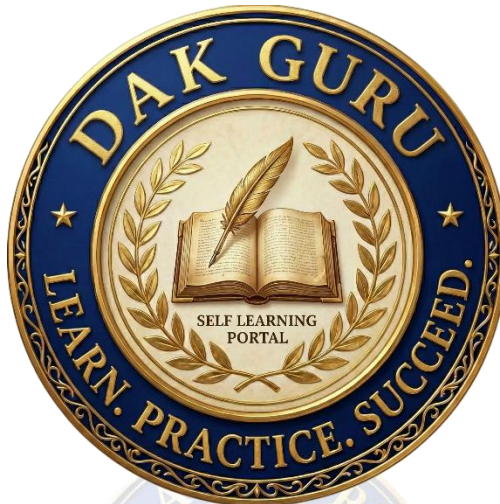

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STUDY MATERIAL

POSTAL MANUAL

VOLUME VII

Railway Mail Service

Based on the Ninth Edition

For LDCE — Inspector of Posts (IP) • PS Group 'B' • PA/SA • Postman / MTS / Mail Guard

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Disclaimer & Notice

Purpose of this booklet. This booklet has been prepared strictly as a study aid for candidates preparing for departmental and competitive examinations conducted by the Department of Posts. It restates and explains the provisions of Postal Manual Volume VII (Railway Mail Service) in a structured, examination-oriented form.

Source. The content is based on the Ninth Edition of Postal Manual Volume VII as hosted by the Department of Posts and on the India Code repository maintained by the Legislative Department, Ministry of Law and Justice, Government of India. Rule numbers and chapter structure follow that primary source.

Not an official publication. This is not a Government publication and carries no official authority. Wherever a question of right, liability, promotion, pay or disciplinary action arises, the reader must rely only on the official Manual, the latest Directorate orders, gazette notifications and SB / DG / DoP&T circulars in force, and not on this booklet.

Editorial additions. Passages marked “In plain terms”, “Exam focus” and “Editorial note” are explanatory aids written by Dak Guru. They are not part of the statutory text. Modernisation notes (for example, references to CSI, IPVS, MNOP, NSH/ICH, AMPC and the MTS cadre) describe the present operational position and are dated and sourced; they supplement, but do not amend, the Manual.

Currency of information. Postal rules are amended from time to time. While care has been taken to reflect the position as of the date of compilation, readers must verify the current status of any provision before relying on it. Dak Guru accepts no liability for any loss arising from reliance on this material.

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Guide

How to Use This Booklet

This booklet follows the **exact chapter and rule structure of Postal Manual Volume VII (Ninth Edition)**. Volume VII deals with the **Railway Mail Service (RMS)** — the arm of the Department of Posts responsible for the conveyance, sorting and transit of mail by rail, road, air and (historically) river. The volume is organised into **eight chapters** and **three appendices**, exactly as reproduced here.

The eight chapters at a glance

Ch.	Subject	What it covers
1	Miscellaneous Rules	Foundational definitions and general rules — departments of a set, late-fee posting, metal tokens, disposal of records, custody of money.
2	General Rules for Transit Sections & Mail Offices	Rules common to all sections and mail offices — stamps & seals, books, portfolio, attendance, daily report, mail abstract, exchange of mails.
3	Sorting Mail Offices	The four departments of a sorting office — Mail, Sorting, Registration and Parcel — and the duties of each Sorting Assistant. Includes AMPC and CRC.
4	Transit Sections & Transit Mail Offices	Duties of the Mail Guard / Mail Agent where only closed bags are handled. Includes the Computerised TMO (CTMO).
5	Record Offices	Duties of the Record Officer — supervision, work-paper examination, token roll, returns and correspondence. Includes HRO computerisation.
6	Mailmen & Van Attendants	Duties of the supporting Group 'C' (erstwhile Group 'D' / now MTS) staff in the Record Office and the mail van.
7	Mail Operations	The science of sorting — handling rates, selections, Post Office sorting, and the speed-vs-economy logic of the network.
8	Bag Accounting	The bag-account system — Unit, District and Circle Bag Offices and the control of empty bags.

The colour-coded study aids

Throughout the booklet you will see three kinds of highlighted boxes. Each has a distinct purpose:

In plain terms. A green box restates a rule in simple language so you grasp the idea quickly. It is a learning aid, not the legal text.

Exam focus. A saffron box flags the points most often tested in objective papers — the exact figures, time-limits, designations and 'who-does-what' that examiners love.

Editorial note. A navy box gives present-day context — how a rule works today under CSI, IPVS, MNOP and the modern hub network. These notes are dated and sourced and are NOT part of the Manual.

Exam focus. Volume VII is heavily definition-based. Master the **designations** (Head Sorting Assistant, Mail Agent, Mail Guard, Record Officer, Sorting Assistant), the **documents** (mail abstract, registered abstract, due mail list, daily report, error/order/guidance books) and the **numbers** (preservation periods, handling rates, the 'fifteen articles' station-bundle rule). These are the backbone of every RMS question.

Chapter 1

Miscellaneous Rules

This chapter sets out the foundational, general-purpose rules of the Railway Mail Service. Many of the most frequently examined definitions and figures live here. The chapter contains **Rules 1 to 19**.

Rule 1. Departments of a set of a Sorting Mail Office

For the distribution of work and responsibility, each **set** of a Sorting Mail Office is divided into **four departments**, each in the charge of a designated official:

Department	Official in charge
(a) Mail Department	Head Sorting Assistant
(b) Sorting Department	Sorting Assistant
(c) Registration Department	Registration Sorting Assistant
(d) Parcel Department	Parcel Sorting Assistant

- (2) Where the number of Sorting Assistants is **less** than the number of departments, the duties of two or more departments are combined and assigned to one Sorting Assistant, according to the sanctioned establishment.
- (3) Where no separate Parcel Sorting Assistant is employed, the parcel duties go to the **Registration Sorting Assistant**. In a set of only **two** Sorting Assistants, the Head Sorting Assistant does the sorting-department work in addition to his own, and the other Sorting Assistant handles both registration and parcel work.
- (4) In sets headed by a **selection-grade** Head Sorting Assistant, the receipt and dispatch of mails and the opening and closing of mail bags are assigned to a senior Sorting Assistant designated the **Mail Sorting Assistant**.

In plain terms. A 'set' is a team of officials working a section or office together. A full sorting office set has four departments; smaller sets simply merge roles. The man in overall charge is always the **Head Sorting Assistant (HSA)**.

Note in the Manual. The Manual itself records that **sorting work is no longer performed in trains** — running sorting sections were abolished and sorting is now done in stationary mail

offices and hubs. The departmental structure, however, still governs how a sorting office is organised.

Rule 2. Posting of prepaid unregistered articles in trains and Mail Offices

- (1) Unregistered articles (letters, postcards, packets) posted in **train letter-boxes** at any time, or in letter-boxes attached to RMS offices during the prescribed late-fee period, must carry the prescribed **late fee in addition to the postage**.
- (2) Articles posted in the van/compartment letter-box are dealt with immediately after the train leaves the station. The stamps are first obliterated. Articles on which the late fee **has** been paid are forwarded by the nearest route. On articles (except postcards) where the late fee has **not** been prepaid, the '**Detained — Late Fee Not Paid**' stamp is impressed; these are made over loose to the first mail office (or a Post Office acting as one) for disposal as though posted there.
- (3) **No article may be received by hand** by an RMS section. Only where the van has no letter-box, or the article is too large for the box, is this rule held in abeyance — such articles are received by hand without scrutiny until after departure, then treated as if posted in the van box.
- (4) Every regular mail van bears a painted notice at the letter-box stating that articles posted there must carry extra postage (late fee) over and above the ordinary postage.

Exam focus. Key trigger: the '**Detained — Late Fee Not Paid**' stamp is used on every article (except postcards) where the late fee was not prepaid. And remember — an RMS section does **not** accept articles by hand, save the narrow exception in clause (3).

Rule 3. Mention of sections in official correspondence

- (1) Whenever a section is named in official correspondence, its **beat must be added in brackets** after the designation, to avoid confusion — for example: **TP 16 (Chennai–Vijayawada)**; the out and in trips being shown as **TP 16 OUT** and **TP 16 IN**.
- (2) If two or more sections share the same beat, the **railway designation of the train** is added when the section is first mentioned.

Note (1): this need not be observed in communications between officials of the same Division regarding that Division's own sections and offices. **Note (2):** a report against a section must also carry the number and date of the set concerned.

Rule 4. Interception or redirection of articles

Except on the authority of the **Director-General** or the **Head of the Circle**, a mail office may **not** (a) redirect any article, or (b) intercept or deliver any article to the addressee.

Note: this does not apply to camp articles for high officers, which are dealt with under Appendix A.

Exam focus. Two authorities only — **Director-General** or **Head of the Circle**. This pairing recurs throughout Volume VII.

Rule 5. Information not to be made public

No person outside the Department may examine any article passing through the post — even one he himself posted — nor may any information about such an article be given to an outsider. **Work papers must not be shown to any official unconnected with the RMS.** An RMS officer who makes public any information received officially renders himself **liable to dismissal**. A request for information from RMS records by another Government officer must be referred to the Circle for orders.

In plain terms. This is the RMS expression of postal secrecy. The penalty named in the rule itself is **dismissal** — a favourite objective-question point.

Rule 6. Date on stamps and seals

The date shown by the date-stamps and seals of a set is that of the **day on which the working hours of the set begin** — not necessarily the calendar day on which an impression is made.

Rule 7. Interruptions to mail movement

Interruptions due to breaches on the railway, floods, accidents or any other cause are reported by the **Head Sorting Assistant** of the set on duty to the **Superintendent, the Inspector and the Record Office**. If the detention is **likely to exceed 6 hours**, it is reported **at once by fax/telegraph** to the Superintendent and the Record Office; for shorter detentions, the fax/telegraph report goes only to the Record Office.

Exam focus. The magic figure is **6 hours**. Above 6 hours → report at once to Superintendent and Record Office. Below 6 hours → only the Record Office.

Rule 8. Extra reserved accommodation in trains

- (1) Where the regular accommodation in a train is inadequate for all the mails, the **Mail Agent/Mail Guard** in charge of a transit section may apply to the railway authorities for extra accommodation for the exclusive use of the Post Office.
- (2) Where a Record Officer or Mail Agent is available, the request is made by him after satisfying himself it is genuinely necessary.
- (3) The requisition is prepared in **four parts** by the Record Officer or HSA. The Superintendent, from the requisitions and daily reports, compiles and submits to the Head of the Circle, **on the 10th of each month**, a return showing the extra accommodation used on each railway in the preceding month.

Exam focus. Numbers to lock in: requisition in **four parts**; monthly return to Head of Circle by the **10th**.

Rule 9. Misconnection of Mail Buses, Trains and Air Services

- (1) Misconnection at junction stations and airports is reported to the **Superintendent** as early as possible by the Record Offices there, per the Telegraphic Message Code or by fax. Misconnection between **air services** is additionally reported by Record Officers to the **Head of the Circle by first post**.
- (2) Offices that open and dispose of misconnected mails must immediately intimate the disposal to the Record Offices of the sections/offices concerned and to the Post Office due to receive the mails.

Rule 10. Circulars of Heads of Circles

- (1) Orders for the general guidance of RMS officials are published in the **Monthly Circulars** of the Head of the Circle, numbered in an annual series, and filed in **Guard Books**.
- (2) Such circulars are **destroyed after three years**, counted from the April following the close of the official year of issue. If still needed, the instructions are incorporated into circle orders or reproduced in a new circular before destruction.

Exam focus. Circulars of Heads of Circles → preserved **3 years** (from the following April).

Rule 11. Receipts to be taken in hand-to-hand exchange

- (1) When registered or parcel articles are transferred loose between sets or offices: if the number is **large**, they are enclosed in a registered/parcel bag and receipt taken

in the registered/parcel abstract of the relieved set; if **small** and time permits counting, they are made over loose under receipt on the duplicate copy of the registered/parcel list.

- (2) In such cases the bag from one set/office to another is shown in the mail list as an '**L**' bag, and the Due Mail List shows exchange of '**L**', '**R**' and '**P**' bags instead of '**D**' or '**S**' bags.

Rule 12. Knowledge of Sorting List and "List of Indian Post Offices"

Every Sorting Assistant must **commit the sorting list to memory** and be able to repeat or write the due mails received and delivered at each exchange. He must know the Head Post Offices of India and the Sub and Branch Offices in account with each, and must know the **PIN code** of all PIN sorting districts. He must keep abreast of additions and alterations in the List of Indian Post Offices. A **sorting case with practice cards** is kept at every Record Office for off-duty practice.

Note: the Superintendent, Inspector or Record Officer may order a Sorting Assistant to attend the Record Office for practice sorting during his rest-time.

In plain terms. The rule captures the core competency of a Sorting Assistant: the sorting list and the PIN map must be in his head, not just on paper.

Rule 13. Supply of sorting list to Sorting Assistants

- (1) Every Sorting Assistant is supplied with the sorting list of his mail office and gives a **receipt** for it.
- (2) Each Sorting Assistant must keep his personal copy corrected up to date; the Record Officer ensures this is done during Record Office attendance.
- (3) Personal copies are accounted for **like metal tokens**. If a sorting list is lost, a nominal cost of **Rupee one** is recovered before a new copy is supplied.

Exam focus. Lost **sorting list** → recover **Re. 1** (nominal). Note this is the sorting list, not the metal token — examiners deliberately mix the two.

Rule 14. Metal Tokens

- (1) A metal token of authorised type must be carried by **all RMS officials except Supervising Officers** who travel on duty in a reserved vehicle/compartment, or who enter the platform to exchange mails. It must be shown on demand to railway guards and ticket examiners.

- (2) Tokens are **Government property**, supplied from the stock depot to the **Head Record Office**, which issues them onward. Each bears the Division name and a serial number and is treated as part of Record Office stock. Every holder gives a receipt, must wear the token on duty, is **personally responsible** for its loss or misuse, and must produce it before his **monthly salary** is disbursed.
- (3) On going on leave, transfer to another Record Office/Division, or quitting service, the holder **returns the token** in exchange for his receipt. As far as possible the **same token** is restored to the original holder on his return from leave.
- (4) On loss, the holder reports at once to the **Record Officer**, who issues a new token and reports to the Superintendent. The holder must **make good the dues as prescribed by the Department**.

Exception: mail carriers attached to Post Offices are supplied authorised tokens of the RMS Division covering that office; the Postmaster acts as the local Record Officer and the Superintendent of Post Offices as the Superintendent, RMS.

Exam focus. Loss of a token is reported **to the Record Officer** (not directly to the Superintendent). The token must be produced **before monthly salary** is paid. The recovery is the cost “as prescribed by the Department” — the Manual gives **no fixed rupee figure**, so do not memorise a fabricated amount.

Rule 15. Relaxation of work on Sundays and P.O. Holidays

- (1) Record Offices may be **entirely closed**, provided urgent work is arranged and the attendance of Sorting Assistants under Rule 26 is arranged for the day before or after the holiday.
- (2) In Mail Offices on Sundays/postal holidays: except the sale of postage stamps and stationery (and booking of registered articles on the usual late fee), **no business is done with the public**; there are **no dispatches to Post Offices**; and staff attendance is reduced to the minimum, relieving as many as possible in rotation.

Rule 16. Memorandum of Distribution of Work

Issued by the **Superintendent** wherever more than one official works in an office or section, the memorandum specifies each official's duties, the attendance hours of sets, and (for a section starting from a station) the hour the set must be present. For a Record Office it is initially prepared by the **Record Officer**; for a mail office or section, by the **Inspector**; in each case it is forwarded to the Superintendent, who furnishes copies to the

office and Inspector concerned. For a section it also shows the proper, evenly-distributed arrangement of bags in the van.

In plain terms. The 'memo of distribution of work' is the master duty chart of a set — who opens which bags, who closes which, attendance times, and bag layout. The Superintendent issues it; the Record Officer/Inspector drafts it.

Rule 17. Disposal of Records

Records are torn and sold as waste paper on the expiry of the period of preservation noted against each. The principal periods are:

Class of record	Period of preservation
Correspondence relating to robberies, thefts, etc. (Inland Post)	1 year after the case is closed
Invoices of articles received from / returned to the Stock Depot	3 years
Order Book of a mail office and a section	3 years
Correspondence on personal files (appointments, leave, pensions, punishments)	3 years after the official ceased to belong to the Department
Work papers of RMS offices and sections	18 months
Correspondence on disposal of registered articles (letters & parcels)	18 months
Other records of a record/sub-record office (with stated exceptions)	18 months
Arrangement Register, Attendance Register and Daily Report	18 months

- (2) The following may **not** be destroyed without the special permission of the **Head of the Circle**: the **Order Book of a Record Office**; the **Nominal Roll of token-holders**; and any work-papers, correspondence or documents relating to an enquiry in progress or a case not finally closed.

Note: Director-General's circulars and General Orders and the Postmaster-General's circulars are destroyed after three years (from the following April). Gradation lists are destroyed three years after new ones issue.

Exam focus. Examiners test the contrast: **work papers, registered-article correspondence, arrangement/attendance registers, daily reports = 18 months**, while **Order Book of a mail office/section, stock invoices, personal-file correspondence = 3 years**. The **Order Book of a Record Office** and the **token nominal roll** need the **Head of Circle's** sanction to destroy.

Editorial note. Beware older notes that quote a single flat figure (such as '3 years for registered abstracts'). The Manual's own table is graded as above, and digitisation under CSI has further shortened the physical retention of several documents. Always confirm a specific period against the current Appendix to Volume V before relying on it.

Rule 18. Postage stamps and stationery for sale

- (1) Every mail office holds a stock of postage stamps and stationery (embossed envelopes, inland letter cards, postcards) for sale; the **Head Sorting Assistant** (or, in a transit mail office, the **Mail Agent/Mail Guard**) is responsible for maintaining a sufficient stock of every kind in demand.
- (2) The amount held is fixed by the **Superintendent**. The first supply is obtained from the nearest **Head Post Office** against a receipt counter-signed by the Superintendent; further supplies are bought from any Post Office through a security-furnished official.
- (3) Stamps are kept in the **office safe**, inside a two-box stamp case — an inner '**Daily Stock**' box and an outer '**Reserve Stock**' box. Only the Daily Stock box is kept out during working hours. Each supply of a denomination is expended before a fresh supply of the same denomination is sold.

Note: a security-furnished Group 'D' (now MTS) official may sell stamps with the Superintendent's approval, but an official employed to deface stamps must not also sell them.

Rule 19. Custody of Government Money

- (1) Government money and valuables are locked in the **cash safe or cash chest**. Each Head Record Office has an office safe; each Record/Sub-Record Office has a safe or chest at the Head of the Circle's discretion. **No private money or property** may be kept in it.
- (2)–(4) Offices with one or more Sorting Assistants (besides the Record Officer) use a **two-lock** arrangement. In a **Head Record Office** one key is held by the **Head Record Officer** and the other by the **Accountant**. In a Record/Sub-Record Office, one key is held by the Record/Sub-Record Officer and the other by a Sorting

Assistant nominated as **joint custodian**. In a single-handed office, both keys are held by the Record/Sub-Record Officer.

- (5)–(6) During working hours the safe may be secured with **one** lock (key with the Accountant in an HRO, or the Record/Sub-Record Officer elsewhere). Beyond working hours it must be secured with **both** locks.
- (7) Where cash must be kept in a safe embedded in a Police Station, GRP post, Treasury or Sub-Treasury, **two safes** are supplied — one (single lock) for working hours and one (double locks) for after hours.

Exam focus. Head Record Office keys: **HRO + Accountant**. Other offices: **Record/Sub-Record Officer + nominated Sorting Assistant (joint custodian)**. Working hours = one lock; after hours = two locks.



Chapter 2

General Rules for Transit Sections and Mail Offices

These rules apply alike to **transit sections** and **mail offices** (sorting and transit), except where obviously inapplicable. Wherever the **Head Sorting Assistant** is mentioned, the official in charge of a set is meant — whether a Head Sorting Assistant, Mail Agent or Mail Guard. In sets headed by a selection-grade HSA, the receipt/dispatch of mails and closing of transit bags are done by the **Mail Sorting Assistant**. The chapter contains **Rules 20 to 46**.

Rule 20. Stamps and seals

- (1) Every set is supplied with: (a) a date stamp, (b) a name stamp, (c) a date-seal, and (d) a 'Detained — Late Fee Not Paid' stamp.
- (2) Each set of a Sorting Mail Office is further supplied with an **insurance seal** in a locked box, which must always remain in the possession of the **Head Sorting Assistant**, who is responsible for its safe custody.
- (3) With each date-stamp and seal a **type-box** is supplied; type not in use and the name stamps are kept in the Record Office (except for offices/sections exempt from RO attendance).

Exam focus. Four stamps/seals per set; the **insurance seal** is the HSA's personal charge. Special date seals also go to the registration and parcel departments where separate Sorting Assistants exist.

Rule 21. Books

The following books are supplied to each set: the **Sorting List** (sorting offices only); the **Guidance Book** (not to transit offices/sections); the **Book of Service Message Forms**; the **Order Book**; the **Telegraphic Message Code**; **Post Office Guide** Parts I & II (not to sections) and Part III (List of Post Offices); the **Classified List of Post Offices and RMS offices**; the **Due Mail List** (which also contains the sorting list); the **PIN Code Directory** (not to transit offices/sections); and **MMS/Air schedules** (not to transit sections).

- (2) Each **Order Book** has 200 serially numbered pages and each **Guidance Book** has 100. **Wilful removal of a page is a serious offence rendering the offender liable to dismissal.**

Note: Volumes II, III, IV, V and VII of the Postal Manual, the Book of Standard Printed Forms, the FR&SR compilation and the GPF Rules are kept at Record/Sub-Record Offices for reference; Branch Office Rules and the Financial Hand Book Vols I & II are kept at Head Record Offices.

Exam focus. Page counts: **Order Book = 200 pages, Guidance Book = 100 pages.** Wilful removal of a page → liable to **dismissal**.

Rule 22. Portfolio and its contents

- (1) Each set of a section is supplied with a **portfolio** — a locked case bearing the section's designation and set number painted on it.
- (2) The portfolio carries the working tools and documents: stamps & seals, bundles of work-papers, Due Mail Lists, the memo of distribution of work, the Error Book, the Order Book, the Book of Service Message Forms, the Telegraph Message Code, writing materials, an ink pad, safety matches, a first-aid box, carbolic soap, a duster, scissors, pen-knife, files and a rubber stamping pad. (Type boxes and type stamps are carried only by sections exempt from RO attendance.)
- (3) The portfolio always remains in the **personal custody of the Head Sorting Assistant/Mail Guard**, who is responsible for its safety.
- (4) A separate **sealed bag** carries the sweeping brush, late-fee notice board, twine, sealing wax, stamp brush, seal holders and wooden blocks, labels and covers.

In plain terms. Think of the portfolio as the set's locked 'office in a box' — every stamp, seal, book and form needed for the trip, in the HSA's personal charge.

Rule 23. Stationery

- (1) The **stationery rate list** issued by the Superintendent fixes the quantity supplied to each set.
- (2) In a mail office, the HSA gives out only a day's requirement at the start of work; the rest is kept locked up.

- (3) For sections, the Record Officer supplies a **month's stationery on the 1st of every month** against a receipt in the stationery register; the stock is kept in a spare bag, sealed with the set's date seal and held under lock at the Record Office.

Rule 24. Hand-bags / brief cases

A hand-bag is supplied to each Sorting Assistant, Mail Guard and Van Attendant of a section for personal luggage. This hand-bag and a roll of bedding (**not exceeding 1 m × 1.2 m in girth**) are the **only personal articles** that may be taken into the mail van. Any Inspecting Officer may require the official to open his hand-bag or bedding for examination.

Exam focus. Only two personal items in the van — the **hand-bag** and a **bedding roll within 1 m × 1.2 m girth**. Anything else is irregular.

Rule 25. Relations of staff with Record Officer

Staff attached to a Record Office are **directly subordinate** to the Record Officer and must carry out his orders in all official matters. The HSA ordinarily receives, **through the Record Officer**, all instructions affecting the sorting list or procedure. It is the HSA's **personal duty** to receive the set's work-papers from the Record Officer — this must never be delegated.

Rule 26. Attendance at Record Office

- (1) Unless exempted, all officials attend **punctually** at the Record/Sub-Record Office during attendance hours and sign the attendance book. Failure to attend is treated as **absence without leave** unless a medical certificate or prior leave is produced. If casual leave for the day is granted, the official must still attend; only **half a day's CL** may be debited; if other leave is granted, **one day's** leave is debited.
- (2) Sorting Assistants/Mail Guards must bring their **metal tokens and rough notebooks**; the Mail Agent/Mail Guard of a section must also bring the **portfolio**. No one leaves until all correspondence requiring disposal has been answered and the HSA has completed the prescribed duties for both the previous and the next trip.

Note 1: the Head of Circle may relax this rule for sections in special circumstances; as a general rule, mail-office staff are exempt from Record Office attendance. **Note 2:** duties prescribed for performance at the Record Office are, for exempted staff, performed during the working hours of the set.

Rule 27. Checking and submission of work-papers

The HSA, assisted by the other Sorting Assistants, checks the set's work-papers in detail — comparing receipt lists with dispatch lists and the entries in the registered/parcel/mail/MO abstracts — and writes up the daily report and extract reports from the rough notebooks **before** the work-papers are sent (in a bag, invoiced in the mail list) to the Record Office. Each Sorting Assistant has his own work-papers examined in his presence by the Record Officer. For offices exempt from RO attendance, the work-papers are sent to the Record Office in a closed, invoiced bag.

Rule 28. Preparation of daily report (M.S. 83)

- (1) The HSA submits to the Superintendent, **through the Record Officer**, a daily report bringing to notice the irregularities observed by the set. It is written from the rough notebooks; each entry names first the office/official at fault, then a concise statement of the occurrence. Every fax/telegraph sent is copied into the report; those received are attached in original.
- (2) Entries are numbered in one consecutive series, each copied into an **extract report** bearing the same number.
- (3)–(4) Where LSG Supervisors are sanctioned, each submits a **daily note** to the HSA for onward transmission. The **Supervisor of a Speed Post Centre** also uses form **MS-83** to report to the Manager, Speed Post.

Exam focus. The daily report form is **M.S. 83** — and the same form is used by the Speed Post Centre Supervisor. The report always travels **through the Record Officer** to the Superintendent.

Rule 29. Important irregularities to be mentioned in the Daily Report

The more important irregularities and occurrences that **must** be entered in the daily report include, among others:

- all irregularities reported by telegraph/fax;
- absence of a carrier appointed to receive or deliver mails (with the mails detained);
- receipt or dispatch of **special bags**; non-receipt of a due mail bag;
- opening of a bag not intended for the office (mislabelled, damaged or suspicious);
- receipt of a bag damaged, insecurely fastened, or with a defective/tampered seal;

- **loss, over-carriage, mis-sending or mis-delivery** of a bag, bundle, press packet, registered article or parcel;
 - misconnection of trains/buses/air services serving a Head Office or Class I / selection-grade Sub Office;
 - insubordination or neglect of rules; duties assigned outside the memo of distribution of work;
 - illness of an official on duty; misuse of bags; disposal of damaged or injurious articles;
 - all irregularities concerning registered articles, insured parcels or insured bags;
 - late receipt/dispatch of mail (mail offices); insufficient light in the van, or non-supply/removal of a van (sections).
- (2) Where a bag or article is received damaged, or anything is missing, the HSA follows the investigation instructions in **Chapter 3 of Postal Manual Volume V**, attaching the seal, twine, bag or list to his daily report where prescribed.

Rule 30. Delivery of empty bags to Record Office

Empty bags remaining from previous trips or spells of duty are sent to the **Unit Bag Office (UBO) / District Bag Office (DBO)** concerned.

Rule 31. Preparation of work-papers

The work-papers for the next trip are supplied by the **Record Officer** to the Mail Agent / Head Mail Guard / Mail Guard, who makes the prescribed entries with the help of the other Sorting Assistants. (The list of work-papers used during a trip is in **Appendix C.**) When filled and stamped, they are submitted to the Record Officer, who stamps the set's daily report.

Rule 32. Receipt of empty bags from Record Office

The HSA receives the empty bags and labels for the next trip, **examines and turns the bags inside out**, and enters them on the receipt side of the mail abstract under "Received from Record Office". He ensures suitable lengths of string are attached to the labels and that string is not wasted in cutting.

Rule 33. Attendance of set on Railway Platform

At **changing stations**, the relieving set must be on the platform **before the train arrives**. At other stations where trains are made up, the set proceeding on a trip must be present

at the hour fixed by the Superintendent — **at least half an hour before departure**. Earlier regular attendance needs the **Head of the Circle's** approval.

Exam focus. Standard platform attendance = **at least half an hour before departure**. Anything earlier as a regular measure needs Head of Circle sanction.

Rule 34. Change of sets at changing station

- (1) When the mails for the changing station have been handed out, the Mail Agent/Mail Guard of the **relieving** set enters the van and takes over the bags from the **relieved** set; the relieved set then quits the van and the rest of the relieving set enters.
- (2) Where bags are too many to examine each in the time available, the Superintendent may (with Regional/Circle approval) authorise the Mail Agent to take over bags, examine each **while the train is in motion**, and telegraph the irregularities at the next (specified) station.

Rule 35. Staff not to leave the van or mail office

Except in special circumstances and with permission of the HSA, Superintendent or Inspector, **no official may leave the mail van at an intermediate station** during the trip, nor leave a mail office during working hours — except that the HSA may leave the office solely to exchange mails.

Rule 36. Window of van to be closed when at platform

When the train is at a platform, the window of the van on the **platform side** is closed **after the mails are exchanged** and kept closed until the train starts. Staff on duty are prohibited from talking to travellers or acquaintances at stations.

Rule 37. Prohibition against smoking, cooking, naked lights and unauthorised persons in mail vans

- (1) Smoking, cooking, the use of naked lights, and the entry of unauthorised persons in a mail van are **strictly prohibited** and render the offender **liable to removal**.
- (2) No stove or private lamp may be carried except with the **written authority of the Divisional Superintendent**, and then only if it contains no combustible substance and is not unpacked.
- (3) Supervising Officers on tour should make surprise checks for these infringements and note each check in the diary; the Mail Agent/Guard is held responsible for allowing such irregularities.

Exam focus. Penalty here is **removal**. A stove or lamp may be carried only with the **Divisional Superintendent's written authority**, packed and without combustible content.

Rule 38. Sudden or serious illness of an official on duty

- (1) When an official **in a mail van** falls seriously ill, the Mail Agent/Mail Guard informs the **Guard of the train** with least delay and reports to the **Superintendent**. The railway staff arrange medical aid and disinfection; for cholera or other infectious disease the sufferer is removed and the mails fumigated.
- (2) When an official **in a mail office** falls seriously ill, the HSA reports by fax/telegraph to the Superintendent; if the HSA himself is ill, the **Senior Sorting Assistant** assumes charge.
- (3) In **single-handed** offices/sections the Superintendent is **invariably** informed by fax/telegraph; otherwise the officer in charge uses discretion.

Rule 39. Mail abstract (M-42 for sections; M-43 for mail offices)

- (1) The mail abstract has two parts — “**Mails**” and “**Bags**”.
- (2) The “**Mails**” part shows, on the left under **Receipts**, the due mails due and actually received and the unusual mails received; and on the right under **Dispatches**, the due mails due and actually dispatched and the unusual mails — bags opened/closed by the office and forward bags shown separately. The forward-bag totals on both sides must agree.
- (3) The “**Bags**” part shows the empty bags of each description due from the UBO/DBO on the receipt side, and the bags dispatched and returned to the Record/Sub-Record Office on the dispatch side. The totals on both sides must agree.

Note 2: for sections, the entries for the out-trip and in-trip are shown separately in the mail abstract.

Exam focus. Form numbers: **mail abstract = M-42 (sections) / M-43 (mail offices)**. It has two parts — **Mails** and **Bags** — and both sides of each part must tally.

Rule 40. Exchange of Mails

- (1) The Due Mail List shows the stations/hours of exchange and where mails are enclosed in transit bags.

- (2) On arrival, the Mail Agent/Mail Guard of a **section** takes delivery of the mails for the set **before** giving out those for dispatch; the Mail Agent/Mail Guard of a **mail office** first gives out the bags for dispatch and **then** takes delivery.

Exception: at important stations with heavy exchange, the Head of Circle may let a section deliver its mails before receiving onward mails, to make room in the van.

- (3) The carrier who exchanges mails with a section is **not permitted to enter the van** — bags pass through the door/window. At a mail office, exchange with the local Post Office is at the door, the carrier not entering.
- (4) Where no mail list is used, a receipt is taken in the receipt book; otherwise the carrier signs the **Mail Peon's Book (Form MS-28)**.

Exam focus. Direction of exchange differs: a **section receives first**, a **mail office dispatches first**. The carrier never enters the van. Receipt without a mail list → **Form MS-28** (Mail Peon's Book).

Rule 41. Cage T.B.

If the Cage T.B. of a mail van is addressed by the originating mail office to the mail office of a **terminal station**, the HSA enters the van, examines the seal and fastening for tampering, opens the Cage T.B., checks the bags against the mail list inside, and takes delivery. The **key of the Cage T.B. is forwarded in a sealed cover**.

Rule 42. Disposal of mails addressed to a section or mail office

- (1) Transit bags addressed to a section/office are opened by the **Mail Guard or Mail Agent himself**; the account bags and branch-office bags inside are checked against the mail lists. In a sorting office the bag addressed to the office itself is dealt with first — parcel bags entered in the mail abstract and transferred (under receipt) to the Parcel Sorting Assistant; mail/BO/packet bags handled per the next chapter.
- (2) **Forward bags** are separated: those for stations on the beat are placed at once in the transit bags (or hung on hooks in station order); those for the terminal station are hung together at one end of the van; sacks for the Record Office are placed in the bag provided.
- (3) Forward bags in a mail office stay in the HSA's custody until dispatch, kept **locked in the mail box**, the key always on his person.

Rule 43. Prompt entry of unusual mails in mail lists

As soon as the received mails are disposed of, forward unusual bags are **at once** entered in the mail lists with which they are to be dispatched — before the train reaches the next station (section) or before the bags are placed in the mail box (office). Done thus, no unusual mail can be left behind. If a special mail list is prescribed, one is prepared.

Rule 44. Preparation of mail lists dispatched and entries in mail lists

- (1) Mail lists accompanying mails are prepared by the HSA **in duplicate using carbon paper**. The list shows the due and unusual mails actually dispatched, with an explanation against any difference from the number due. The **carbon (lower) copy** goes to the addressee office; the **original (upper) copy** is kept on record. Each page is date-stamped and signed.
- (2) When mails pass through intervening offices, the forwarded mail list is entered under **“Due Mails — Transit bags”** in the next office's mail list, e.g. **“M-26 In to M-33 Out — 1 Mail list 4 with Bags.”**
- (3) A mail list is prepared daily for the Record/Sub-Record Office detailing surplus unusual bags addressed to it.

Rule 45. Closing of transit bags

- (1) Before a transit bag is made up, the bags inside are checked against the mail list; the condition, cord, label and seal of each are examined by the HSA/Mail Guard/Mail Agent, who places them with the mail list in the transit bag and then labels, closes and seals it.
- (2) **Transit bags must always be closed and sealed in the presence, and under the direct supervision, of the HSA / Head Mail Guard / Mail Agent.**

Rule 46. Completion of mail abstract

Before reaching the terminal station (section) or before closing work for the day (office), the mail abstract is written up and completed. The “due” figures entered at the Record Office are reproduced under **“Actually received / Actually dispatched”** after adjusting for any excess or short receipts/dispatches explained in the mail lists. Unusual mails and bags are then entered; both parts are **totalled and balanced**; and finally the mail lists are stitched together in order and attached to the abstract.

Chapter 3

Sorting Mail Offices

A **Sorting Mail Office** is one where letters and parcels are actually sorted (not merely passed on as closed bags). Its work is divided among **four departments** — Mail, Sorting, Registration and Parcel — each treated as a separate Part in this chapter. The chapter contains **Rules 47 to 104** (Rules 51, 52, 53 and 60 stand deleted). It also incorporates the **Automatic Mail Processing Centre (AMPC)** and the **Computerised Registration Sorting Centre (CRC)**.

Part I — Mail Department

Rule 47. Duties and responsibilities of the Head Sorting Assistant

- (1) The HSA's duties primarily cover the **receipt, custody and dispatch of mails**, the opening of bags addressed to the office (other than registered, registered-packet and parcel bags) and the closing of bags made up by the set (other than those three). His responsibility begins when mails are made over to him and continues until they pass to another department or are dispatched.
- (2) He is responsible that bags received are carefully examined; that registered, registered-packet and parcel bags (including insured bags) are **promptly transferred** to the departments concerned; that unregistered articles he handles are correctly sorted; that the mail is properly packed and securely fastened, labelled and sealed; that **torn or unserviceable bags are not used**; and that all irregularities are promptly detected, with complete and correct work-papers.
- (3) He (or the LSG Supervisor in charge of the insured-parcel branch) is further responsible that **every insured bag is opened in his presence**, the number of insured parcels is correct, each is examined and **accurately weighed in his presence** by the Parcel Sorting Assistant, and that every insured bag for dispatch is closed and sealed in his presence.

In plain terms. The HSA is the linchpin of the set — he handles the plain mail himself but acts as the responsible supervisor for the registered, parcel and insured streams. The insured-bag rule (open, count and weigh in his presence) exists so responsibility for any loss can be pinned to a specific office.

Rule 48. Supervision of set

Although each Sorting Assistant answers for his own department, the HSA is responsible for the **general supervision** of all departments and for work in strict accordance with the rules. He examines the Sorting Assistants from time to time on their knowledge of the sorting list, explains his duties to any newly-appointed Sorting Assistant, and ensures the B-orders in the guidance book and the T.B. orders in the guard books are understood.

Rule 49. Sorting of unregistered letter mail articles

The HSA (or LSG Supervisor) is **specially answerable** for the work of the sorting department and must not only supervise it but **assist in sorting** unregistered articles when not supervising. Where the memo of distribution of work assigns him the preparation of certain mail bags, he is personally responsible for that work, and the rules for Sorting Assistants in Part II apply to him equally.

Rule 50. Attendance of set

- (1) The HSA must be in office at the appointed time and see that the staff are present in good time and neatly dressed.
- (2) Every set keeps an **attendance register** in the same numerical order as the memo of distribution of work; officials sign it and also sign the daily report in the same order.

Rules 51, 52 and 53 — Deleted.

Rule 54. Opening of mail bags

Mail bags addressed to the office are opened by the **HSA himself** so work can be distributed without delay. **Express mail bags are opened first** and their contents disposed of as in the next three rules. The HSA must know which express bundles are to be picked out and disposed of first, and must have **every emptied bag turned inside out and examined** so nothing remains inside.

Rule 55. Registered bags received

The registered bag taken from each mail bag is examined for good condition and intact cord and seal, then transferred **under receipt (in the registered abstract)** to the **Registration Sorting Assistant**. An unsealed empty registered bag with a blank registered list is checked to see the list bears **“Nil”** in the total and is signed and date-stamped.

Rule 56. Parcel mail articles received

- (1) Parcel mail articles taken from each mail bag are checked against the total in the parcel list and transferred (with the parcel list, under receipt in the parcel abstract) to the **Parcel Sorting Assistant**. An insured bag is first examined for good condition and intact cord, label and **both seals**.
- (2) Every insured bag opened in a sorting office must be **weighed by the Parcel Sorting Assistant in the HSA's presence**, the number of insured parcels verified, and each examined and weighed. Strict observance lets responsibility for any misappropriation be fixed between the offices of dispatch and receipt.

Exam focus. An insured bag carries **two seals**; it is opened, the parcels counted, and **weighed in the HSA's presence**. This 'weigh in presence' theme is examined repeatedly.

Rule 57. Opening of other bags

Branch-office bags addressed to the mail office are opened by the **Mail Sorting Assistant himself**, and the bags with the unregistered articles inside are handed to the Sorting Assistant concerned.

Rule 58. Receipt of articles and bags for dispatch

All articles and bags for dispatch are brought by the Sorting Assistants of the other departments to the **Mail Sorting Assistant**, who is responsible that they are received in sufficient time before the dispatch hour.

Rule 59. Certificate of posting

In mail offices, certificates of posting are granted to the public per the rules in the Post Office Guide.

Rule 60 — *Deleted.*

Rule 61. Unregistered articles for dispatch

Unregistered articles for dispatch are received from the Sorting Assistant; before placing them in the mail bags the HSA examines some to correct sorting errors. He pays special attention to **station bundles** and ensures that paid and unpaid station bundles are made up for all Post Offices for which there are **more than fifteen** paid, or unpaid and insufficiently-paid, station articles. He sees that bundles are tied round the middle with a properly filled **check slip** on top.

Exam focus. The ‘**more than fifteen**’ threshold for making up a station bundle is one of the most-tested numbers in Volume VII.

Rule 62. Preparation of mail for dispatch

In good time before the dispatch hour, the bags for dispatch are sorted — mail and packet bags made up by the set being sorted with the forward bags, those not sent loose being sorted by the transit bag in which they go. The **Due Mail List** guides this work, and only sound, strong bags are used.

Rule 63. Parcel and packet bags for dispatch

Parcel bags made up by the set are received from the Parcel Sorting Assistant; the Mail Sorting Assistant examines each bag, cord and seal, grants a receipt in the **parcel abstract**, and enters the bag in the **mail abstract**. Parcel and packet bags not sent loose may go inside the same transit bags as mail bags if dispatched with the letter mail; the Due Mail List shows which are sent loose and which enclosed.

Rule 64. Examination and arrangement of work-papers

- (1) Before closing work, the HSA obtains the registration and parcel work-papers, checks each abstract's **receipt-side total against its issue-side total**, sees the work-papers have been checked and the irregularities noted, signs the abstract, and arranges all the work-papers in a bundle.
- (2) This examination is an **important duty** to be performed by the HSA personally **before the Sorting Assistants leave** the station or office.

Rule 65. Custody of stamps, seals, keys and blank forms

- (1) Stamps and seals are always locked up when not in use; before closing, the HSA collects and locks them. The **insurance seal always remains in the HSA's possession** (or the LSG Supervisor's, where closing of insured bags is delegated to him).
- (2) All office keys are kept by the HSA on his person, though during working hours the sorting-case keys are entrusted to the Sorting Assistants concerned. He is responsible for the custody of the registered-journal books in use and in stock.

Rule 66. Final duties before quitting office

The HSA examines **each sorting compartment** to ensure no article is left unsorted; checks the articles in the list; sees the stationery, stamps, seals and books are placed in the

portfolio; that the bag of empty/surplus bags for the Record Office is sealed and labelled; that the mail box and sorting cases are secured; and that the office is swept. He **personally examines the sweepings, used labels and broken seals** before they go into the waste bag, then locks the room and keeps the key — or, if a succeeding set comes on, hands over charge and the deposit mails by entry in the mail list.

Exam focus. Three personal end-of-duty checks by the HSA: every **sorting compartment** empty, the **sweepings/used labels/broken seals** examined, and charge handed over by **entry in the mail list** if a succeeding set follows.

Part II — Sorting Department

Rule 67. Duties and responsibilities of the Sorting Assistant

The Sorting Assistant's duties cover the **sorting of unregistered articles** (posted in the office, handed over by the HSA, or received in bags) and the preparation for dispatch of the mail bags assigned to him. His responsibility begins on receipt of the unregistered articles and continues until they are handed to the HSA for dispatch. He is responsible for correct sorting and for preparing **station bundles** for all offices with more than fifteen station articles (and express/deferred bundles where prescribed).

Rule 68. Importance of correct sorting

- (1) The **most important work** of the RMS is the sorting of unregistered articles. The Sorting Assistant must take the greatest care not to mis-send; **no excuse is accepted** for mis-sending an article whose post-town or PIN is printed or distinctly written.
- (2) A Sorting Assistant who **habitually mis-sends** clearly-addressed articles is **unfit for his post** and liable to removal or reduction to a lower grade.

Exam focus. Habitual mis-sending of clearly-addressed mail → the Sorting Assistant is declared **unfit**, liable to **removal or reduction**. A classic 'consequence' question.

Rule 69. Preliminary duties

Before sorting begins, the Sorting Assistant places the **sorting list, PIN Code Directory and List of Indian Post Offices** on the ledger of the sorting case; fixes the **sorting-case labels** in the sockets (as far as possible one per office/section for which bags or station bundles are made); keeps twine/rubber bands, scissors and check-slips ready; and hangs the dispatch bags (each with its label loosely attached) on the bag-drop stands.

Rule 70. Separation of articles posted

Articles posted in the office are examined, **faced**, and separated into **(a)** fully prepaid articles (letters and postcards kept in separate heaps to ease stamping) and **(b)** articles appearing insufficiently paid, unpaid, or chargeable for breach of conditions.

Rule 71. Stamping and removal to sorting case

Articles are stamped and **at once** removed to the ledger of the sorting case; on no account may they remain on the stamping table after stamping.

Rule 72. Unregistered articles received from Head Sorting Assistant

- (1) Unregistered articles in the mail bags arrive in station and sorting bundles. **Station and territorial bundles for onward transmission are placed unopened** in the bags for forwarding; the **sorting bundles are then opened** and their contents dealt with, taking care not to disturb the facing.
- (2) If a station bundle (or District/TD bundle), though required, has not been prepared by an office, a **report is made** against the office responsible.

Rule 73. Description of sorting case

The **diagram prepared by the Superintendent** shows how the pigeon-holes of the sorting case are arranged; the pigeon-holes are painted with the approved diagram. Sorting Assistants must sort **strictly in accordance with the diagram** and make no deviation.

Rule 74. Sorting of articles

- (1) Articles are sorted into the compartments per the prescribed diagram, the destination of each being carefully read first. Acknowledgements are sorted to the **sender's** address. Camp articles are sorted per the Superintendent's T.B. orders in the guard book.
- (2) Articles posted in the office are dealt with first, then those in the mail bags; bags are opened **one at a time**, station bundles dealt with first.
- (3) As each sorting bundle is opened, the check-slip is moved to the bottom and any **mis-sent** articles likewise placed below it, so that only wrongly-included articles remain when the slip comes up again; these mis-sent articles are then date-stamped and re-sorted.
- (4) In any doubt about destination, reference is made to the HSA or the **List of Indian Post Offices**.

Rule 75. Clearance of compartments of sorting case

As sorting proceeds and compartments fill, their contents are removed at intervals to the dispatch bags; periodic clearance lets sorting proceed faster.

Rule 76. Examination and packing of sorted articles

- (1) When sorting is done, the sorted articles for dispatch are **examined and packed** — i.e. faced and bundled.
- (2) The Sorting Assistant is responsible for examining and properly packing the articles for the bags assigned to him in the memo of distribution of work; **examination is an important duty which must never be neglected.**

Rule 77. Process of examination and packing

Unregistered articles are carefully examined to correct errors and to tax insufficiently-paid articles. As examination proceeds, articles are separated by class of bag; for articles addressed in a regional language, the post-town transcribed in English by the office of posting is verified where time permits. The examined articles are then put in **labelled bundles of suitable size, tied tightly with thin twine.**

Rule 78. Sorting Assistants to help one another when necessary

If there is no time for a Sorting Assistant to examine and pack his bags, he asks the HSA for the help of another Sorting Assistant, who then becomes responsible for the articles he handles.

Rule 79. Transfer of sorted articles to Head Sorting Assistant

In good time before dispatch, the unregistered articles for dispatch are placed in the mail bags and the bags handed by the Sorting Assistant to the HSA.

Rule 79-A. Automatic Mail Processing Centre (AMPC)

AMPCs are established in cities with heavy and widely-varying mail volumes where manual sorting cannot be completed in a reasonable time. Sorting in an AMPC is a **two-stage** process:

- **Advanced Compact Suite (ACS).** A mechanical desk at which trained operators convert **PIN-coded** articles into **bar-coded** articles — a red bar-code is imprinted below the PIN code; the next article presents itself automatically.

- **Letter Sorting Machine (LSM).** Power-driven machines that sort bar-coded mail at **30,000 articles or more per hour** into about **200 selections** per program, the sorted bundles being tied by bundling machines and dropped into destination bags.
- **Culling.** The preliminary operation separating **machinable** from non-machinable mail; flimsy articles and those containing objects (samples, etc.) are excluded.
- **Establishment.** An AMPC is headed by a **Manager**, assisted by Assistant Managers and an Accountant, with specially-trained coders and LSM operators.

Exam focus. LSM speed = **30,000+ articles/hour**, sorting into about **200 selections**. The desk that bar-codes PIN-coded mail is the **ACS**. Separating machinable mail is **culling**.

Part III — Registration Department

Rule 80. Duties and responsibilities of the Registration Sorting Assistant

The Registration Sorting Assistant (RSA) handles the **receipt, custody, sorting and dispatch of registered articles**. His responsibility begins on receipt of registered and registered-packet bags from the HSA and continues until the bags he makes up are transferred back. He is responsible that the bags and articles are fully examined and correctly disposed of, securely fastened and sealed, handed over in time, and that his work-papers are complete. (In larger offices, transfer of registered articles other than insured may be by bulk entry; **insured articles are always transferred by detailed entry.**)

Rule 81. Registered abstract

- (1) The registered abstract has two parts — **“Receipts”** and **“Issues”**. The Receipts side shows the total registered articles received with each registered list (and, in a mail office, those booked in the office), the insured articles among them, and any registered bundles made up; the Issues side shows the corresponding figures dispatched and the registered bundles opened. **Every** due registered bag, registered-packet bag and registered bundle opened or made up must be entered.
- (2) Both sides must agree and the abstract is signed by the RSA.

Rule 82. Preliminary work

Before starting, the RSA takes over from the HSA the empty bags, stationery, registered lists, registered-bundle envelopes and the registered abstract to be used.

Rule 83. Treatment of articles presented for Registration

- (1) An article presented for registration is examined for good condition and full prepayment of postage, registration fee and (for air mail) the air fee, being weighed if necessary. The sender is advised to add his name and address. A **receipt is prepared in the registered journal**, recording the addressee, office of destination and (for packets/letters above minimum weight) the value of stamps affixed; the serial number and date are written boldly on the article.
- (2) The receipt is date-stamped, detached and handed to the sender (except for an article registered on service, where it stays in the journal). All articles registered each day are entered in the registered list.
- (3) An article believed to contain anything the insurance of which is **compulsory** is **refused registration**.
- (5) An inland registered article found to contain gold coin or bullion exceeding **Rs. 2,500** in value is dealt with under **Rule 122 of Postal Manual Volume V**.

Rule 84. Preparation of registered articles for dispatch

- (1) A **registration No. slip** bearing the journal number and an impression of the No.-slip name stamp is pasted to the **upper left-hand corner** of the address side.
- (2) Stamps on the article are defaced by the RSA himself with the minimum number of date-stamp impressions.
- (3) The acknowledgement (if any) is fastened to the back of the article by thread tied crossways, so the two cannot separate in transit; the thread must **not** pass through the article, which is then locked up until dispatch.

Rule 85. Receipt of registered bags and registered packet bags

As the mail bags are opened, the RSA receives from the HSA the registered bag taken from each, and any registered-packet bags. Each is made over **under receipt in the registered abstract**, the RSA first carefully examining the seal, cord, label and condition of each bag and seeing that all due bags are correctly received.

Rule 86. Treatment of Money Order Bundles and the money orders in them

Money order bundles invoiced at the foot of registered lists are received in registered bags; their number is checked against the list. The RSA opens each bundle addressed to the office, verifies the money orders against the money-order check-slip on top, sorts them per the sorting list, and dispatches them in money-order bundles. For a Post Office,

money orders **for payment** and **for onward transmission** are placed in separate bundles marked **“Station”** and **“Sorting”**. Where six or more money orders are for one Post Office, they are bundled separately, addressed to it and marked **“Station.”**

Rule 87. Treatment of High Value Money Order Bundles and Money Orders

In a sorting office the RSA verifies from the registered list whether the bag contains an **M.O. list (MO-75)** and the high-value money orders, opens the high-value sorting M.O. bundles, and cross-checks each HVMO's number and office of issue against the list. He makes station HVMO bundles where two or more are for one station, preparing duplicate lists of contents (one copy placed in the bundle), tying and sealing the bundle and marking **“HVMO ...”** with the number. A separate **“M.O. Abstract”** is maintained on the lines of the registered abstract, with the HSA exercising the same supervision.

Rule 88. Sorting of registered articles

Registered articles (including those posted in the office) are sorted into the registration sorting case per the diagram, the destination read carefully first; a forward registered bundle is treated as a single article. **The registration sorting case must always be locked when not in use, the key remaining with the RSA during working hours.**

Rule 89. Mis-sent registered articles

A registered article received mis-sent or needlessly delayed is noted on the registered list, stamped, shown to the HSA, and forwarded to the correct destination. (Registered articles presented for booking during the fixed period are accepted on **Sundays and postal holidays** on payment of the usual late fee.)

Rule 90. Insured bundles

Where two or more insured letters go from one office to another, they are enclosed in an **insured bundle** addressed to the latter (for RMS town-delivery places, only if two or more are for the same town office). The letters are placed in an insured envelope (or a dosuti bag), the bundle numbered to match the number of letters, preceded by **“I.B.”** with the office of destination below. The bundle is closed and sealed and the weight in grams written in words.

Rule 91. Transfer of registered and registered packet bags to Head Sorting Assistant

In good time before dispatch, the registered-packet bag is handed to the HSA **under receipt in the registered abstract**.

Rule 92. Completion of registered abstract

Before closing work, the RSA completes the registered abstract, checks that both sides agree, and examines the **check sheet for insured articles** to confirm every insured article received was noted on receipt and ticked off on dispatch. The registered lists are then stamped and stitched together in the order entered on the receipt side.

Rule 93. Delivery of work-papers, etc., to Head Sorting Assistant

After checking his work-papers, the RSA makes them over to the HSA, together with any spare empty registered bags, the stationery to be replaced in the portfolio, and the **key of the registration sorting case**.

Rule 93-A. Computerised Registration Sorting Centre (CRC)

Where a Computerised Registration Sorting Centre is in operation, these rules **substitute** the manual Rules 80, 81, 82, 85, 87, 88, 89, 91, 92 and 93. The duties are distributed among four roles:

- **System Administrator** (the in-charge): maintains system security and the secrecy of passwords; enters all **master data** (set, staff, opening/closing bag details, mail-agency, PIN-code and sorting-district masters); and generates the **MIS reports** (sorter, set-wise, booking/delivery-office, transmission and login-logout reports).
- **Supervisor**: opens the set with the available RSAs, allocates opening and closing bags, ensures timely (including interim) dispatch, and verifies the **insured check list** before dispatch.
- **Registration Sorting Assistant (RSA)**: works the allotted position, opens allotted bags, enters article details, transfers/acknowledges articles between RSAs (in packet or parallel mode), closes his bags in time and uses the **close-day** option.
- **Insurance Sorting Assistant (ISA)**: acknowledges and keeps **safe custody** of all insured articles till dispatch, generates the insured check list for the Supervisor, and submits an individual abstract at the close of day.

Editorial note (current position). The 'CRC' concept has since evolved. Under the **Mail Network Optimization Project (MNOP)**, the old CRCs were re-designated as **Registered L1 / L2** offices, and from **December 2024** (DoP OM No. 30-10/2022-D) Registered hubs were merged with the Speed Post hubs so that **Speed Post and Registered articles are now processed together at common NSH/ICH hubs**. Live receipt, opening, closing and dispatch of accountable mail is handled in the **CSI** environment through the **IPVS** application, with online Due Mail Schedule Lists and system-generated abstracts. Sources: DoP / CEPT MNOP material and OM No. 30-10/2022-D dated 17 Oct 2024.

Part IV — Parcel Department

Rule 94. Duties and responsibilities of the Parcel Sorting Assistant

The Parcel Sorting Assistant (PSA) handles the **receipt, custody, sorting and dispatch of parcel mail articles**. His responsibility begins when parcels are received from the HSA (in parcel bags or loose) and continues until made over again. He is responsible that bags and articles are carefully examined and correctly disposed of, parcel bags securely fastened and sealed, torn bags not used, and his work-papers complete.

Rule 95. Documents accompanying parcel mail articles

- (1) Every **insured parcel** is accompanied by an **acknowledgement**; an uninsured registered parcel for which an acknowledgement is due is marked "**A.D.**" and similarly accompanied. **Unregistered parcels** bear "**UNREGISTERED PARCEL**" in capitals and carry no documents.
- (2) If a parcel arrives without its due acknowledgement, it is shown to the HSA and the irregularity noted on the parcel lists.

Rule 96. No. slips affixed to parcel mail articles

A slip bearing a printed number and the No.-slip name stamp of the office of posting is pasted to every parcel except unregistered parcels — known collectively as **No. slips** (a **Parcel No. Slip** on a parcel; a **V.P. No. Slip** on a value-payable article). The **weight in grams** of an insured parcel is recorded on its insured parcel No. slip.

Rule 97. Parcel abstract

- (1) The parcel abstract has two parts — "**Receipts**" and "**Issues**" — showing the ordinary, registered and insured parcel mail articles received with, and dispatched with, each parcel list.
- (2) Both sides must agree and the abstract is signed by the PSA.

Rule 98. Preliminary work

Before starting, the PSA takes over from the HSA the empty bags, stationery, parcel lists and the parcel abstract.

Rule 99. Receipt of parcel and insured bags and loose parcel mail articles

Parcel bags addressed to the office, and the parcel mail articles (including insured bags) with their parcel lists, are made over by the HSA to the PSA **under receipt in the parcel abstract**; the PSA must see that a parcel bag, or parcel list with articles, or a blank parcel list, is received from **every** office authorised to forward parcels to the office.

Rule 100. Mis-sent parcel mail articles

A parcel received mis-sent is noted on the parcel list, **stamped**, shown to the HSA, and forwarded to the correct destination.

Rule 101. Sorting of parcel mail articles

- (1) Parcels (with their acknowledgements) are sorted into the parcel sorting case per the sorting list.
- (2) The **parcel sorting case must always be locked when not in use**, the key with the PSA during working hours.
- (3) An insured parcel addressed or redirected to a **non-insurance office** is nevertheless forwarded to it.

Rule 102. Transfer of parcel bags and parcel mail articles to Head Sorting Assistant

In good time before dispatch, the parcel bags (or the parcel mail articles with the parcel list, or the blank parcel list) for each mail bag are handed to the HSA **under receipt in the parcel abstract**.

Rule 103. Completion of parcel abstract

Before the close of work, the PSA completes the parcel abstract, checks that both sides agree, examines the **insured-article check sheet**, stamps the parcel lists, and stitches them together in the order entered on the receipt side.

Rule 104. Delivery of work-papers, etc., to Head Sorting Assistant

After checking his work-papers, the PSA makes them over to the HSA, with any spare empty bags, the stationery to be replaced in the portfolio, and the **key of the parcel sorting case**.



Chapter 4

Transit Sections and Transit Mail Offices

A **transit section** or **transit mail office (TMO)** deals only with **closed bags** — no detailed sorting of contents is done. The official in charge is the **Mail Guard** (in a section) or the **Mail Agent** (in a TMO). The chapter contains **Rules 105 to 115**, plus **Rule 115-A** on the Computerised TMO.

Rule 105. Duties and responsibilities of the Mail Guard or Mail Agent

- (1) Their duties cover the **receipt, custody, sorting (of bags) and dispatch** of articles posted in the van/office and of closed mails. Responsibility begins when articles are cleared from letter-boxes or closed mails are made over, and continues until delivery or dispatch. They have **nothing to do with the contents** of closed mails made over for disposal, but they **open transit bags addressed to the section/office** and dispose of the bags inside.
- (2) They are responsible that bags are carefully examined and correctly disposed of, securely fastened, labelled and sealed; that unserviceable bags are not used; and that work-papers are complete and irregularities promptly reported.

In plain terms. The key distinction from Chapter 3: a transit office handles **bags, not loose contents**. The Mail Guard/Mail Agent moves closed bags onward but does not open and sort the letters inside them.

Rule 106. Attendance of set

- (1) An **attendance register** is kept in the TMO; every Mail Agent/Mail Guard signs and enters his attendance time.
- (2) At the appointed time the Mail Agent/Mail Guard of a section is present at the railway station, sees the other officials present and the work-papers and articles brought, and that staff are neatly dressed with no personal luggage beyond hand-bags and bedding.
- (3) In running sections without attendance registers, officials sign the **daily report** in numerical order against their designations.

Rule 106-A. Examination of van

The Mail Agent/Mail Guard examines the van interior, fittings, glass windows and lamps for damage. He may be required to **pay the cost of damage** to internal fittings caused by him, or not detected and reported by him, on examination at the start of the trip or as soon as possible afterwards.

Rule 107. Preliminary work

The Mail Agent/Mail Guard sees the hand-bags and bedding placed away from the operational area, opens the portfolio and arranges its articles, distributes the work-papers and articles per the memo of distribution of work, and arranges the empty bags. If the trip starts at a **changing station**, he first takes delivery of the mails from the relieved set, examines the bags in its presence, and signs the sectional and special mail lists.

Rule 108. Receipt and dispatch of mails

The sorting-office rules for receipt and dispatch of mails apply, so far as relevant, to a transit section/office. In transit sections the **exchange of mails is done at both doorways** of the van (main entrance and storage position) to avoid detention.

Rule 109. Disposal of unregistered articles

Unregistered articles posted in the van/office or received from a mail peon are sorted per the instructions of the Divisional Head; ordinarily a **sorting mail bag is closed for each office** with which mails are exchanged.

Rule 110. Certificate of posting

Certificates of posting are granted to the public by **transit mail offices only** (not by transit sections), per the Post Office Guide.

Rule 111. Treatment of late letters

The instructions in **Rule 61 of Postal Manual Volume V** on the treatment of late letters apply also to transit mail offices.

Rule 112. Registration of articles

- (1) With a few exceptions, every transit mail office is authorised to **register** articles of the letter mail, but **not to insure** them.

- (2)–(3) The conditions are in the Post Office Guide; the Mail Agent must observe the procedure in Chapter 3 of this Volume and in Chapter 2 of Postal Manual Volume V for preparing registered lists, bundles and bags.

Exam focus. A TMO can **register but not insure**. Certificates of posting are granted by **transit mail offices only**, not by transit sections.

Rule 113. Hours fixed for closing the mails

The instructions on this subject are in **Rule 58 of Postal Manual Volume V**.

Rule 114. Preparation of mail for dispatch

In good time before the train arrives (section) or the dispatch hour (TMO), the bags for delivery/dispatch are sorted — those not sent loose by the transit bag in which they go — and the Mail Guard/Mail Agent satisfies himself the number of bags is correct.

Rule 115. Final duties before quitting van or office

- (1) The Mail Agent/Mail Guard examines the fittings and lamps for damage/loss, replaces the stamps, seals and books in the portfolio, puts the empty bags for the Record Office in the bag provided, labels and seals the letter bag, gives out the mails for delivery and (if ending at a changing station) makes over the mails for the relieving set with the sectional mail list.
- (2) He checks the listed articles, sees the office swept and secured, then locks the room and keeps the key — or hands over the deposit mails and charge to a succeeding set by entry in the mail list.

Rule 115-A. Computerised Transit Mail Office (CTMO)

Computerisation of a TMO allows any bag passing through to be located, keeps a watch on due mails, and estimates extra mail. Duties are distributed among three roles:

- **System Administrator** (overall in-charge): maintains system security and password secrecy; enters **master data** (set, staff, transport sectors, route schedules, mail-agency profiles, due bags and due transfer bags); generates MIS reports; and manages back-ups.
- **Head Mail Agent**: opens the set with available Mail Agents, allocates mail-agency branches and bags, fixes dispatches on changes of transport mode, reopens TBs to add/remove bags, generates the mandatory reports (due bags not received/dispatched), and ensures timely closing.

- **Mail Agent:** works the allotted position, receives and opens TBs, transfers and acknowledges bags, prepares and dispatches TBs for the allotted transport at the scheduled time, forwards bags to the next set, and uses the **close-day** option.

Editorial note (current position). Under CSI, bag handling at TMOs is now done through **IPVS**, with **bag scanning** introduced for unregistered mail and online Due Mail Schedule Lists flowing between offices. The TMO's core function — receiving and dispatching **closed bags** without opening them — is unchanged; computerisation has added end-to-end bag tracking. Source: DoP / CEPT MNOP-CSI material.



Chapter 5

Record Offices

A **Record Office** is the stationary headquarters that supports the sections and mail offices attached to it — preparing, checking and filing their work-papers and supplying their forms, bags and stationery. These rules apply also to **Head Record Offices** and **Sub-Record Offices** except where obviously inapplicable. The chapter contains **Rules 116 to 146**, plus **Rule 146-A** on HRO computerisation. (Rules 132, 133 and 134 stand deleted.)

General Rules

Rule 116. Authority of Record Officer

- (1) The Record Officer's authority extends **solely to the staff attached to his Record Office**.
- (2) He may order Sorting Assistants to do **overtime**, transfer them temporarily between sets/sections in urgent cases, summon a Sorting Assistant during rest-time to enquire into losses or complaints, and make temporary arrangements for sudden illness — **every such case being at once reported** to the Superintendent in his daily report.
- (3) He may permit **mutual exchange of duties** between Sorting Assistants so long as it causes no extra expenditure and does not interfere with the work.

Rule 117. Supervision of work

The Record Officer exercises **general supervision** over the Sorting Assistants, making himself acquainted with their character and capabilities and ensuring they work strictly per the rules. He warns those who are careless and reports persistent offenders to the Superintendent; he encourages rest-day practice sorting; and he inspects the articles supplied to sets — always when a Head Sorting Assistant is transferred between sets.

Rule 118. Record of orders regarding practising test-card sorting, etc.

The Record Officer keeps a **rough notebook** to record orders to Sorting Assistants for practice card sorting (each signing against the entry), and to record the results of examining portfolios and the book of postmarks and the cleansing of stamps and seals.

Rule 119. Distribution of work

The distribution of work fixed by the Superintendent in the memo of distribution of work must be **strictly maintained** by the Record Officer.

Rule 120. Arrangement Register

Each Record Office keeps an **Arrangement Register** for every set of a mail office and running section attached to it. An extract — showing the designations per the memo of distribution of work and the names of the officials composing the set — is furnished by the Record Officer to the HSA of every set.

Rule 121. Nominal Roll of metal tokens to be kept at Record Office

- (1) The Record Officer keeps a **nominal roll** of the holders of all metal tokens received, a separate page per token recording successive holders. For tokens not issued or lost, the remark “**In Stock**” or “**Lost by (name)**” is entered, with the manufacturing cost plus incidental charges recovered.
- (2) Receipts for issued tokens are filed in serial order with the roll; **all unissued tokens are kept locked in the office safe.**

Exam focus. The token **nominal roll** is the Record Officer's permanent register of who holds which token — and (per Rule 17) it cannot be destroyed without the Head of the Circle's sanction.

Rule 122. Register of sorting lists

The Record Officer keeps a manuscript **register of sorting lists** received, a separate page per list recording successive holders. For lists not issued or lost, “**In Stock**” or “**Lost by (name)**” is entered, with the nominal cost of **Rupee one** recovered in cash.

Rule 123. Hours of attendance

The **Superintendent** fixes the attendance hours of Record Office staff and the sections attached, and the Record Officer insists on punctuality. An attendance register is kept in which every official (including the Record Officer) and every Sorting Assistant signs and enters his time **in the presence of the Record Officer.**

Rule 124. Attendance on Railway Platform

Where the Record Officer must attend the platform on the arrival/departure of trains, the trains to meet and the work to do are laid down in the memo of distribution of work. (The

Head of the Circle may dispense with his presence where an Inspector supervises the transfer of mail bags.)

Rule 125. Travelling of Record Officer

The Record Officer's duties **do not entail travelling**; but in emergencies (a break on the railway, etc.) he may be deputed by the Superintendent to the spot to arrange mail transport, and in special cases — with the Head of the Circle's sanction — on camp-mail duty for high officers on tour.

Duties during Attendance Hours of Sets

Rule 126. Work to be done during attendance hours

During the attendance hours of a set, the Record Officer's work comprises: taking over the work-papers for the previous trips; issuing the work-papers for the next trips; taking over and issuing the empty bags; communicating the Superintendent's/Head of the Circle's orders on sorting-list and other changes and requiring explanations of irregularities; and attending to bag-account correspondence. Staff are not detained at the Record Office longer than necessary.

Rule 127. Importance of proper examination of work-papers

The **most important duty** of the Record Officer is the examination and filing of work-papers, to be performed with the utmost care. **A Record Officer who neglects it renders himself liable to dismissal** or other statutory penalty.

Exam focus. Note the parallel: neglect of work-paper examination → the **Record Officer** is liable to **dismissal**, just as a Sorting Assistant who habitually mis-sends is liable to removal.

Rule 128. Points to be observed in examining work-papers

In examining a set's work-papers, the Record Officer sees that all documents are received from the HSA/Mail Agent; that no forbidden correction is made and all permissible corrections are attested; and that the papers are complete and neat. He checks whether the **registered/parcel/MO/mail abstracts tally**, and if not, whether a report was made in the daily report; in token of this he **signs the abstract**.

Rule 129. Disposal of daily reports

- (1) After examination, daily reports of sets are stamped and signed by the Record Officer and forwarded with his own daily report to the Superintendent (or Deputy Superintendent), each with its extract reports attached.
- (2) Extract reports on **unimportant** irregularities by offices outside the Division are detached and sent direct to the Superintendent or first-class Postmaster concerned.
- (3) **Check-slips** attached to daily reports are detached and forwarded by first mail to the Superintendent or first-class Postmaster concerned.

Rule 130. Issue of forms to sets

After the previous work-papers are examined and filed, the Record Officer makes over to the HSA/Mail Guard the **forms and labels** for the next trip and the set's **type boxes**, seeing that the bag labels are impressed with the correct name stamps and are serviceable.

Rule 131. Inspection of work-papers prepared

When the work-papers for the next trip are prepared and submitted, the Record Officer examines them to see they are properly and neatly filled and the documents (including bag/transit-bag labels) duly stamped — an **important duty** in token of which he **stamps the set's daily report**.

Rules 132, 133 and 134 — Deleted.

Rule 135. Examination of sweepings

The **sweepings of mail vans** returned by the Mail Guard are examined **personally by the Record Officer** to see no postal article, contents or fallen-off stamps are among them; the daily sweepings of mail offices are similarly examined as soon as possible.

Rule 136. Delivery Book

- (1) All communications from the Superintendent calling for explanations from Sorting Assistants are sent to the Record Officer for delivery, and the replies returned through him. A **Delivery Book** is kept with columns for the number and date of the Superintendent's communication, the Sorting Assistant's signature on receipt, and the date the reply was forwarded. These communications are **not numbered** by the Record Officer or entered in his own correspondence register.
- (2)–(3) The Record Officer makes over the communications under receipt in the Delivery Book and requires explanations of all detected irregularities. **No Sorting**

Assistant may leave the Record Office until all references for his set are answered, and none may take away an unanswered communication.

Rule 137. B. Orders and T.B. Orders

- (1) On receipt of a **B order** from the Superintendent, the Record Officer has it copied into the **guidance book** of each set concerned; **T.B. orders** / **Tour orders** are filed separately in a guard file. He explains each order to the Sorting Assistants/Mail Guard, who **initial it** in evidence of understanding.
- (2) He must see that only the B orders concerning a set are copied into its guidance book, and is responsible for any omission or error.
- (3) When a B/T.B. order becomes obsolete, cancelled or amended, the prescribed **“Cancelled (or amended) by ... No. ... of 20...”** remark is written across the copies, under the Record Officer's signature for B orders, and the cancellation mentioned in his daily report. The orders for each year are filed in a guard book in serial order.

In plain terms. Two streams of orders: **B orders** are copied into each set's **guidance book** (working instructions), while **T.B. orders** are kept in a **guard file**. Both are explained to the staff, who initial them.

Records, Returns and Correspondence

Rule 138. Filing of work-papers

- (1) At month-end, the daily bundles of a transit section's work-papers are arranged into **two monthly bundles** — one for out-trips, one for in-trips — each labelled with the section and month.
- (2) A mail office's work-papers are put in **daily bundles**, then arranged into a monthly bundle labelled with the office and month.
- (4) Once filed, work-papers may **not** leave the Record Office unless required by a Supervising Officer, and no one may open a bundle except in special circumstances noted under the Record Officer's signature.
- (5)–(6) Where a Supervising Officer removes a work-paper, an **attested copy** is left in its place with a note explaining the removal and naming the officer; returned papers are at once re-filed.

Rule 139. Preservation of bags and records for enquiry

Whenever an investigation into loss or abstraction is made, the Supervising Officer orders preservation of the relevant records and material objects — **check slips, RB and IB covers, seals, cords, labels and bags**. The Record Officer keeps them in his **personal custody**, allows no access except with the Investigating Officer's permission, and does not destroy them without that permission.

Exam focus. In a loss case, the **Record Officer** holds the seals, cords, labels, bags and RB/IB covers in **personal custody** — and only the **Investigating Officer** can authorise their destruction.

Rule 140. Periodical returns to be submitted by Record Officer

The principal periodical returns submitted by the Record Officer (all to the Superintendent) are:

Return	Period	Date of submission
Daily Report	Daily	At the close of each day
Indent for stationery	Half-yearly	To reach the Superintendent by 10 Feb and 10 Aug
Indent for case labels	Monthly	To reach the Superintendent by the 15th
Indent for articles of stock	As required	Whenever articles are required
OTA bill (Form AGC-37)	Every 4-weekly cycle	Within a week of the cycle ending
Extract from register of miscellaneous sums received/disposed	Monthly	3rd of each month

Rule 141. The Record Officer's daily report

- (1) The Record Officer submits a daily report to the Superintendent, accompanied by the daily reports of the HSAs and Mail Guards of the attached sections and the Sorting Assistants' written explanations.
- (2) Irregularities that must invariably be noted include: absence of a Sorting Assistant, Mail Guard or van peon from a set proceeding on a trip (with particulars and extra duties ordered); non- or late attendance on the attendance day; negligence shown by complaints or careless work-papers; **loss of a Sorting Assistant's metal token or sorting list**; and loss of or damage to any article supplied.

- (3) The report also carries the closing **cash balances** — pay-and-allowance cash in hand, the permanent advance for contingencies (cash and vouchers), and the permanent advance of postage stamps (cash and stamps) — jointly signed where a joint custodian exists.

Rule 142. Corrected copies of sorting lists

On the day train timings are revised, the Record Officer submits to the Superintendent and the Principal of the Training Centre **corrected copies of the sorting lists** of all attached mail offices, incorporating all monthly sorting orders, sorting memos and A orders, the corrections made legibly in **red ink** quoting the order number and date. Their correct and punctual submission is the Record Officer's personal responsibility.

Rule 143. Disposal of Superintendent's communications

All communications from the Superintendent must be disposed of speedily, and Sorting Assistants' replies sent without delay. The Record Officer arranges the communications in the order of attendance of the sets. **Delay is treated as evidence of laxity** proving the Record Officer unfit for his appointment.

Rule 144. Inward Register for complaints

An **Inward Correspondence Register (Form Corr. 2)** for references on public complaints is kept in all selection-grade Record Offices. It records cases bearing the file mark **CR**, all public-complaint cases, and all **search bills**. The Record Officer (or authorised Supervising Officer) goes through it **once a week (every Saturday evening)** to ensure all references have been answered.

Exam focus. The complaints register is **Form Corr. 2**, reviewed **every Saturday**. Cases marked **CR** and **search bills** are entered in it.

Rule 145. Monthly account bundle

On the **5th of every month**, the Head Record Officer submits, under a service-registered cover, the **monthly account bundle** for the previous month — **(a)** to the Head of the Circle / Regional PMG, the monthly **contingent bill** with vouchers; and **(b)** to the Superintendent RMS, the **memorandum of disbursement of salaries and travelling allowances** with acquittance rolls. After check, the documents are returned, impressed with a special stamp, and verified by the Head Record Officer.

Rule 146. Filing of acquittance rolls and other documents

- (1) Acquittance rolls are numbered in a consecutive monthly series in the Head Record Office, **No. 1** being the roll for the Head Record Office itself.
- (2) Rolls and disbursement memoranda are kept loose in cardboard covers until year-end, then **bound into books** (the binding done at the Head Record Office, the binder not removing the rolls).

Note: acquittance rolls for staff whose Establishment Returns go to the Postal Accounts Office, and for whom Service Books/Rolls are maintained, are bound in cloth (not leather), as they are preserved for **six years only**.

Exam focus. Acquittance-roll binding for Postal-Accounts staff is **cloth**, preserved **6 years**. The monthly account bundle is submitted on the **5th**.

Rule 146-A. Computerisation of the HRO

HRO computerisation integrates the mail offices with their Head Record Office and the Divisional Office on a **one-time data-entry** principle, with unique codes for employees, designations, Post Offices and mail offices. It lets the HRO perform accounting, checking and search-bill follow-up with speed and accuracy, data flowing from the mail offices to the HRO by modem with the Divisional Superintendent's approval over a network. In this system the **Head Record Officer functions as the Systems Administrator**.

Editorial note (current position). These functions are today subsumed within **Core System Integrator (CSI)** and **HRMS**, where employee, pay and establishment data are maintained centrally rather than office-by-office. The HRO's accounting and reconciliation role continues, now executed through SAP-based CSI modules. Source: DoP / CEPT CSI material.

Chapter 6

Mailmen and Van Attendants

This short chapter sets out the duties of the supporting staff — **Mailmen** (attached to Record Offices) and **Van Attendants** (attached to sections). It contains **Rules 147 to 152**.

Mailmen

Rule 147. Duties of Mailmen

One or more **Mailmen** are attached to each Record Office to carry the articles supplied to sections between the Record Office and the mail van, to load and unload mails in vans, to convey them to and from the mail office, and to perform similar duties.

Rule 148. Duties in the Record Office

The Mailman attends the Record Office as required and gives help wherever needed. He keeps the office and furniture clean, sees the **ink pads** are serviceable (renewing the cloth when needed), and that the **stamping ink** is of proper consistency.

Rule 149. Attention to hand-trucks

Where hand-trucks are used, one Mailman is detailed (under the Superintendent's orders) to look after them — greasing the wheels, keeping the vehicles in order and reporting any need for repair to the Record Officer.

Van Attendants

Rule 150. Duties of Van Attendants

In transit sections, an official designated **Van Attendant** is attached to each set as a general assistant. His chief duties are to **stamp articles and documents, face letters and packets** posted in the van letter-box, and help the Mail Guard/Mail Agent to pack, close and seal bags. He should stamp with rapidity and clearness and tie and seal bags with facility.

Note: in mail offices, these duties are performed by one of the porters.

Rule 151. Duties in the Record Office

The Van Attendant attends the Record Office with his set on attendance days, helps the HSA take over the bags and labels, **reverses the bags and attaches the string** to the labels,

mounts labels on wooden blocks where required, keeps the set's stamps and seals clean, changes the moveable type, and stamps the next trip's work-papers.

Rule 152. Duties in the mail van

The Van Attendant is present on the platform at the fixed attendance time. On entering the van he helps the Mail Guard/Mail Agent arrange the mails, stamps articles made over to him, assists in packing, tying and sealing bags, faces articles posted in the van letter-box, and performs any other general work required.

Editorial note. The posts of Mailman and Van Attendant were erstwhile **Group 'D'** posts. Following the Sixth Central Pay Commission, the Group 'D' cadre was reorganised into the **Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS)** cadre, and these functions are now discharged by MTS officials. The functional descriptions in the Manual remain valid; only the cadre nomenclature has changed.



Chapter 7

Mail Operations

This chapter explains the **science and logic of sorting** — how the network balances speed against economy by minimising the number of times an article is handled. It contains **Rules 153 to 160**.

Rule 153. Introduction

- (1) Mail Operations — the system of transmission from collection to delivery — is the **core function** of the Department and an immensely complex system, resting on the **twin pillars of speed and economy**. Speed without economy raises cost to prohibitive levels; economy without speed causes consumer dissatisfaction. A healthy blend of the two is the goal.
- (2) Both are retarded by **rehandling** — the more often an article is handled, the greater the cost and delay. The accepted norm is that the rate of handling within one office should **not exceed 1.6 per article**, and the rehandling within the system as a whole should **not exceed 1.8 per article** on average (the maximum being **three** handlings, for a Circle-bundle article passing station → TD/District → Circle selections).
- (3) **District-based sorting** (introduced after sorting sections were abolished) eased the Sorting Assistant's task — he need not remember Head Offices and exceptions, only read the address and place it in the district pigeon-hole. Post Office sorting was widened to relieve pressure on the mail office for outward mail.

In plain terms. The whole chapter turns on one idea: **fewer handlings = faster and cheaper mail**. Hence the numerical targets — about 1.6 handlings within an office, 1.8 across the system, with a hard ceiling of 3.

Exam focus. Lock in the three numbers: handling within an office ≤ 1.6 ; rehandling across the system ≤ 1.8 ; maximum handlings = 3 (station 1, TD 2, District 2, Circle 3).

Rule 154. Manual Sorting

- (1) **Norms for detailed sorting.** Detailed sorting on a full sorting case for a Circle is done if its mail **exceeds 6,000**; on half a detailed table (30–40 selections) if between **3,000 and 6,000**; with fewer selections if between **500 and 3,000**; and **not at all** if under **500** (unless mail is concentrated for one area and labelled bundles can be taken out).

- (3) **Types of selection** are Station, District, TD or Circle. A **station selection is best** (no further handling). A District/TD bundle is preferred over a station bundle only where it averages **more than twice** the letters.
- (5) **Disposal from the preliminary table** is limited to station, TD and District articles; all other mail goes to the detailed table.
- (8) **TTBs** prepared by Post Offices and mail offices are, as a rule, opened only in the Circle addressed, not by intermediary mail offices.
- (9) **Territorial RBs and MO bundles** are prepared by Post Offices for each State when the number of registered lists / money orders is **10 or more**, and need not be opened en route unless detailed sorting for that State is being done.

Exam focus. Detailed-sorting thresholds: >6,000 full case; 3,000–6,000 half table; <500 none. Territorial RBs/MO bundles at **10 or more**. Station selection is always the most efficient.

Rule 155. Sorting Pattern

The sorting pattern must be designed so that the largest number of preliminary-table selections of the linked mail office are reflected in the Post Office's sorting-case diagram, minimising rehandling in the mail office. Selections are based on the **actual traffic pattern of the last two years**. Separate arrangements exist for inward and outward mail.

Rule 156. Closing of bags

Bags are closed according to the sorting list and the due mail list, observing the selection logic above so that the rehandling norm is met. (The detailed closing procedure for each class of bag is in Chapters 2 to 4.)

Rule 157. Checking of quality of sorting

The quality of sorting is checked by the supervising staff through mis-sort and mis-despatch monitoring and the examination of daily reports and error books, so that habitual mis-sending is detected and corrected.

Editorial note (current position). Quality of sorting is today monitored through the **MNOP performance-review system**, under which each Speed Post / Registered hub is reviewed fortnightly against **eleven Key Performance Indicators** computed on the central server — including D+x scan compliance, **mis-sorts**, duplicate bar-codes, missing PIN codes and invalid bag-labels. Source: DoP / CEPT MNOP material.

Rule 157-A. Sample Surveys of Mail

Periodic **sample surveys** of mail are conducted to study the traffic pattern, validate the selections provided on the sorting cases, and revise the sorting diagrams in line with changes in mail volume and direction.

Rule 158. Second Class Mails

Second-class mail (book packets, registered newspapers, printed papers, etc.) is sorted and dispatched separately from first-class mail, with its own sorting-case diagrams where the volume warrants.

Editorial note. Under the merged hub network effective December 2024, printed books, periodicals, registered newspapers, sample/pattern packets and blind literature are processed under a **separate sorting diagram** and sent by **surface routes only**, dispatched under **green-coloured bag labels**. Source: DoP OM No. 30-10/2022-D.

Rule 159. Sorting Equipment

The type of **sorting equipment** (the number of pigeon-holes in the sorting case) is selected office by office according to the traffic pattern, but whatever the equipment, it must satisfy the **1.8-handling norm**. Optimum equipment maximises TD and District selections and minimises Circle selections.

Rule 160. Miscellaneous

Local variations in mail handling are permissible within the framework of these rules, since mail differs qualitatively and quantitatively from place to place. The rules provide a definite framework within which flexibility is allowed to suit local conditions.

Chapter 8

Bag Accounting

The final chapter governs the **bag-account system** — the machinery that keeps empty mail bags in circulation under control, so that bags are neither wasted, hoarded, nor put to irregular use. The chapter contains **Rule 161** and the bag-accounting framework.

Rule 161. Bag Accounting

- (1) The object of the bag-account system is threefold: to **cut the circulation of empty bags to the minimum**; to ensure an **adequate working stock** of bags in each office; and to ensure bags are **not withdrawn for irregular use or misuse**.
- (2) For the purpose of bag accounting, offices are organised into a hierarchy of **Bag Offices**:

Bag Office	Role
Unit Bag Office (UBO)	The basic accounting unit. Every Post Office is, for bag-account purposes, a Unit Bag Office, holding and accounting for its own bag balance.
District Bag Office (DBO)	Controls and balances the bag accounts of the Unit Bag Offices in its district; receives surplus empty bags and redistributes deficiencies.
Circle Bag Office / Central Bag Office	Controls the bag accounts at the Circle level and arranges supply from, and return to, the stock depot.

- (3) A **Memorandum of Authorised Bag Balance** is issued by the **Senior Superintendent / Superintendent of Post Offices or RMS** fixing the bag balance each office may hold. Empty bags surplus to this balance are returned promptly (per Rule 30, to the UBO/DBO concerned), and deficiencies are made good from the controlling Bag Office.

In plain terms. Picture three tiers: every Post Office is a **Unit Bag Office**; districts have a **District Bag Office** above them; and the Circle has a **Circle/Central Bag Office** at the top. The 'authorised bag balance' is the agreed stock each office may keep — anything extra flows back up the chain.

Exam focus. Hierarchy to memorise: **UBO → DBO → Circle/Central Bag Office**. Every PO is a **Unit Bag Office**. The authorised bag balance is fixed by the **Sr. Supdt./Supdt. of POs or RMS**. Empty surplus bags go back to the **UBO/DBO** (Rule 30 link).

Editorial note (current position). Bag accounting is now performed electronically. Under CSI, **bag scanning has been introduced even for unregistered mail** at Transit Mail Offices, and bag movement between offices is tracked online through **IPVS** Due Mail Schedule Lists, with reconciliation reports (e.g. the SAP T-code for bag KPIs) available centrally. The three-tier UBO/DBO/Circle control concept remains the conceptual basis. Source: DoP / CEPT MNOP-CSI material.



Appendices

Appendices

Volume VII closes with three appendices. They are summarised below; for operational use the full text of each appendix in the Manual should be consulted.

Appendix A — Rules relating to Camp Articles

Appendix A governs **camp articles** — letters and other articles addressed to high officers of Government (the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister, Governors, Ministers and other high dignitaries) while on tour, and articles posted by them. Such articles are enclosed in special **Camp Bags** (or Special Bags) and dealt with under the special instructions of the **Director-General** and the Superintendent's **T.B. orders** kept in the guard book. They are kept distinct from ordinary mails, given priority, and the rule against interception/redirection (Rule 4) does not restrict their proper treatment.

Exam focus. Appendix A = **camp articles** for high dignitaries on tour, carried in **Camp/Special Bags** under the Director-General's instructions. This is the express exception referred to in Rule 4.

Appendix B — Relations between the Railway and the Post Office (train timings)

Appendix B sets out the rules governing the relations between the **railway administration and the Post Office in regard to train timings** — how the Department requisitions accommodation, how alterations in train timings are intimated and acted upon, and how the sorting lists and due mail lists are kept in step with the railway timetable. The conveyance of mails by rail is regulated by the arrangements between the Department and the railways, the Department having the right to require carriage of mails and suitable accommodation for them.

Appendix C — List of work-papers issued to sections and mail offices

Appendix C lists the **work-papers** issued to a set for use during a trip or spell of duty — the daily report, mail abstract, registered abstract, parcel abstract, MO abstract, due mail list, sorting list, mail lists, error/guidance/order books and the various lists and slips. The principal forms are tabulated overleaf for quick reference.

Principal Forms used in the RMS (quick reference)

The following are the forms most often encountered in Volume VII. **Form numbers should be confirmed against the current Book of Standard Printed Forms**, as some have been renumbered over successive editions.

Form	Name	Purpose
M.S. 83	Daily Report	The set's daily report of its trip / working hours (also used by the Speed Post Centre Supervisor).
M-42	Mail Abstract (sections)	Account of mails and bags received and dispatched by a transit section.
M-43	Mail Abstract (mail offices)	Account of mails and bags received and dispatched by a mail office.
—	Registered Abstract	Account of registered articles and registered bags handled by the set.
—	Parcel Abstract	Account of parcel mail articles handled by the set.
MO-75	Money Order List	List of high-value money orders carried in a registered bag.
—	Due Mail List	Shows the bags due to be received and dispatched, and the exchange stations/hours.
—	Sorting List	Instructions for sorting articles to the correct bag (kept in the Due Mail List).
MS-28	Mail Peon's Book	Receipt book signed by the carrier where no mail list is used.
Corr. 2	Inward Correspondence Register	Register of public-complaint references (CR cases) and search bills.
AGC-37	OTA Bill	Overtime allowance bill submitted by the Record Officer each 4-weekly cycle.

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End of Postal Manual Volume VII – Railway Mail Service

This booklet has restated the eight chapters and three appendices of Postal Manual Volume VII in their original sequence, with study aids and dated, sourced notes on the present operational position. For every question of right, liability or procedure, rely on the official Manual and the latest Directorate orders in force.

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